But equally, they are a sign of honest introspection. A power that is serious about self-improvement should not shrink from such an undertaking.

How has Indian foreign policy evolved since Independence? Understanding that is done best by dividing into six phases, each a response to a different global strategic environment. The first phase, from 1946 to 1962, could be characterized as an era of optimistic non-alignment. Its setting was very much of a bipolar world, with camps led by the US and the USSR. India's objectives were to resist the constraining of choices and dilution of its sovereignty as it rebuilt its economy and consolidated its integrity. Its parallel goal, as the first of the decolonized nations, was to lead Asia and Africa in a quest for a more equitable world order. This was the heyday of Bandung and Belgrade, the peak of Third World solidarity. It also saw energetic Indian diplomacy from Korea and Vietnam to Suez and Hungary. For a few years, our position on the world stage seemed assured. The 1962 conflict with China not only brought this period to an end, but in a manner that significantly damaged India's standing.

The second phase, from 1962 to 1971, is a decade of realism and recovery. India made more pragmatic choices on security and political challenges while addressing a paucity of resources. It looked beyond non-alignment in the interest of national security, concluding a now largely forgotten defence understanding with the US in 1964. External pressures on Kashmir, especially from the US and UK, mounted in this period of vulnerability. The global context remained bipolar, but it now saw the emergence of limited cooperation between the US and USSR. South Asia happened to be a particular area of convergence and Indian diplomacy had to face the superpowers together, as it did in 1966 in Tashkent. It was also a period when domestic challenges were particularly acute, ranging from political turbulence to economic distress. But for our purposes, what is important is that even though the stress levels were higher, we came through an anxious period without great damage.

The third phase, from 1971 to 1991, was one of greater Indian regional assertion. It started with the decisive dismantlement of an India-Pakistan equivalence through the creation of Bangladesh, but ended with the IPKF misadventure in Sri Lanka. The larger environment by now was